

RAHUL'S CONNECT WITH THE COMMON MAN HAS MADE HIM A CLEAR WINNER

enough not to make the same demand from the parent organisation. "He wants to expand the party's base beyond the caste and community," says Congress General Secretary Digvijay Singh, who is clearly emerging as both his philosopher and guide.

Although Rahul began with a lone ranger scale of operations, asking NGOs to organise his rural jaunts, he has reluctantly realised the importance of including the party organisation into his scheme of things. After all, that is what a leader does; he takes everyone along. The old-timers are struggling to master their BlackBerrys and laptops. A new jargon, too, is quietly slipping into place. The Department of Publicity was reprimanded for their lengthy pamphlets. Instead, Rahul asked for bullet points. At meeting of the party's thinktank on future challenges, he wondered how they could attract "new stakeholders" to the party and suggested that they talk about "opportunities" instead of 'challenges'. After that, sundry Congressmen puffed up both their blowdried hair and their corporate jargon.

Restoring the Politics of GRACE

He has little patience for the cap-in-hand culture of the party, instead he believes in the hands-up style of governance. Whenever he attends village gatherings, he asks the oldest in the group to raise his hand and name three things wrong with the organisation. "Rahul has an inquisitive mind, always asking questions about urban and rural India. And he is a great listener," says N.R. Narayana Murthy, founder of Infosys, who has interacted with him on a number of projects. It could be because he lived abroad for so many years, studying at Harvard and Cambridge that there is this profound desire to understand his country. It is a familiar sight to see him in some remote village, standing amid a group of elders, hands behind his back, head down, just looking up briefly to ask a quick incisive question.

Later, he also impressed Murthy's wife Sudha with his public school manners when he insisted on carrying her suitcase after a flight to Hubli. "He simply said you are older than me, and picked up the bag," recalls Murthy. "There's



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WHAT RAHUL IS DOING IS NOT JUST engaging with the young and the underprivileged but also trying to give them a sense of empowerment.

a certain quiet coolness to him, which is attractive. He's very non-flashy. There's an air about him which, perhaps, can only be summed up in that most Indian word, *khandaani*," says one of his non-political friends who points out that even at social gatherings two things are never missing from Rahul's conversation—the NREGA and Youth Congress. Which, at times, can get a bit boring for Capital's cocktail crowd.

The age of Rahul has begun. Instead of the old politics of patronage, he talks a language of empowerment. It's an era where a Dalit in a far-flung village has more chance of dining with the future ruler of India than a Union minister in Lutyen's Delhi. Certainly, it's a cultural revolution incomprehensible to the pachyderms of his own party, which is, perhaps, too old and tired to come to terms with the enigma of Rahul's arrival. India has taken note and is waiting for the next act.

with Subhash Mishra in Lucknow